Students Studying in The United States

FINAL TERM

F-1 and J-1 students are required to maintain enrollment in on-ground courses during their final academic term. This page will help students understand how to maintain their status in their final term of enrollment.

FINAL TERM ENROLLMENT

Congratulations on approaching the end of your academic program! As you prepare to complete your degree, it's important to understand the enrollment requirements for your final term and the steps you'll need to take to ensure a smooth transition to whatever comes next.

Critical Requirement: Continuous Enrollment Through Your Final Term

As an F-1/J-1 student, your final term requires continuous enrollment and on-ground presence for the **entire** duration of that term — this applies whether your final term falls in **Fall, Spring, or Summer**. The same rules apply across all three terms: you must maintain active enrollment and on-ground presence for the full duration of the term in which you complete your degree.

Final Term Reduced Courseload (RCL)

If you don't need a full course load to finish your degree requirements, you may be eligible for a Final Term Reduced Course Load. No SEVIS authorization from OGS is needed for a Final Term RCL, though we strongly recommend confirming with your academic advisor that all graduation requirements have been met. To qualify, you must meet all of the following criteria:

- **Enroll in all remaining courses** needed to complete your academic program
- **Maintain on-ground presence** throughout your final term – you must enroll in on-ground courses for the duration of the term
- **Online course limitation**: Only one class in your final term may be online. If you have only one class left to complete, it must be in-person (review limitations on online course enrollment) (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-students/understanding-visa-requirements/guidelines-on-maintaining-status/)
- **No first-half-only enrollment**: Unless approved for a mid-semester degree conferral, you may not enroll only in courses that occur in the first half of the term with no enrollment in the second half

Exception for overseas completion: If you are eligible to finish your program finish their program online from overseas (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/forms-and-guides/finish-degree-online-from-overseas/) – however, your SEVIS record will be terminated and you will no longer maintain eligibility for F-1 or J-1 benefits.

Second Final Term RCL: In rare situations, a student may request a second Final Term RCL if they are unable to complete their degree requirements in the final term. This is usually limited to students who received a failing grade for a required course in their final term. No more than two consecutive Final Term RCL approvals may be granted. If you need to request a second Final Term RCL, please contact OGS (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/contact/) to schedule an appointment with a Designated School Official (DSO).

UPDATING YOUR I-20/DS-2019 PROGRAM END DATE

Your I-20 (F-1 students) or DS-2019 (J-1 students) must reflect a program end date that corresponds with your actual final term of enrollment. **If your I-20/DS-2019 currently shows a program end date beyond your final term, OGS is required to update it to align with your graduation term.**

OGS will manage this update as follows:

- **F-1 students applying for Post-Completion OPT:** Your anticipated program completion date will be confirmed through the **Certificate of Program Completion** (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/forms-and-guides/certificate-of-program-completion/), which is completed as part of the OPT application process. This includes students with mid-semester degree conferrals. OGS will update your I-20 program end date at that time.
- **J-1 students applying for Academic Training (AT):** Your DS-2019 program end date will be updated by OGS as part of the Academic Training (AT) process
- **All other students:** OGS will update your I-20 or DS-2019 program end date upon receiving final confirmation of your graduation term from the Registrar.

Please be aware: A future-dated program end date on your I-20 or DS-2019 does not mean your program has been extended. OGS will proactively shorten your document to reflect your actual final term.

PLANNING YOUR NEXT STEPS POST-GRADUATION

As you wrap up your program, you have several paths forward. You might be:

- Preparing to depart the U.S.

- Transitioning into a new degree program
- Applying for Post-Completion employment authorization (OPT/Academic Training)

Please review OGS' page on Leaving Northeastern (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-students/leaving-northeastern/) to learn more about your options after graduation!

Additional Resources

- **Transcripts**: Request official transcripts through the Registrar's Office (https://service.northeastern.edu/registrar?id=kb_article_view&sysparm_article=KB000019947)
- **Diplomas**: Submit diploma questions directly to diplomas@northeastern.edu (mailto:diplomas@northeastern.edu)
- **Commencement**: Contact commencement@northeastern.edu (mailto:commencement@northeastern.edu) with your NUID for ceremony-related questions

KEY RESOURCES

Finish Degree Online from Overseas » (https://myogs.northeastern.edu/istart/controllers/client/ClientEngine.cf serviceid=EFormFinishdegreefromoverseas0ServiceProvider#_ga=2.618 1559522075.1564500084)

This e-form is for students who wish to leave the U.S. and complete their program abroad. OGS will terminate a student's SEVIS record once this form is submitted.

Intent to Complete Program » (https://myogs.northeastern.edu/istart/controllers/client/ClientEngine.cf serviceid=EFormIntenttoCompleteProgram2ServiceProvider)

RELATED ARTICLES:

Guidelines on Maintaining Status (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-students/understanding-visa-requirements/guidelines-on-maintaining-status/)

Transferring Out (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/current-students/understanding-visa-requirements/transferring-out/)

Applying For F-1 Post-Completion OPT (https://international.northeastern.edu/ogs/employment/off-campus-employment/applying-for-post-completion-opt-f-1/)

CONTACT OGS

354 Richards Hall
360 Huntington Avenue
Boston, MA 02115
+1-617-373-2310
OGS Service Portal (https://service.northeastern.edu/ogs)

OFFICE HOURS

Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.-5:00p.m.
(Note: We are closed on Tuesdays from 3:00pm – 4:00pm for all staff training and meeting).
Phone Hours:
Monday-Friday: 8:30a.m.–4:30p.m. ET

SOCIAL

(https://www.facebook.com/NortheasternOGS/) (https://www.youtube.com/channel/UCrMAnObKFBqnSINJw

 © 2026 Northeastern University



Cookie Preferences ()